

The Deck Cost Guide.

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Most deck pricing online quotes **materials only** — then the real bids land at double. Here's the honest math, using manufacturer material data plus what installation actually adds — and a real bid broken into line items so you can see where every dollar goes.

Step 1 — Materials

Composite decking boards (Deckorators, Trex, TimberTech) run roughly **\$8–14 per sq ft** for the boards themselves. Add the substructure (pressure-treated framing, footings, hardware) and railing, and all-in materials land around **\$20–30 per sq ft** for a typical composite deck.

Step 2 — Add 50–100% for installation

Industry-wide, labor runs 50–60% of a finished deck's total cost — professional installation adds **\$15–35 per sq ft** on top of materials. The rule of thumb: take your materials number and add 50–100%. A \$12,000 materials list is a \$18,000–24,000 finished deck. Height, slope, access, and design complexity decide which end you land on.

WHERE THE MONEY ACTUALLY GOES



Substructure + its labor ~38% · decking & railing labor ~30% · railing material ~12% · decking boards & fasteners ~20%. The boards you agonize over are a fifth of the bill.

What that means by deck size

Installed composite, single level, with railing — national data; Front Range labor tends toward the upper half.

Size	Materials	Installed
12×16 (192 sq ft)	\$4,500 – \$6,500	\$8,000 – \$13,000
16×20 (320 sq ft)	\$7,000 – \$10,500	\$13,000 – \$25,000
20×24 (480 sq ft)	\$10,500 – \$15,500	\$19,000 – \$37,000

For calibration: the 2025 Zonda Cost vs Value report puts the national-average 16×20 composite deck addition at about \$25,000 — and wood at about \$18,000.

...and by material

Size sets the scale; the surface you choose sets the rate. Typical installed ranges per square foot, Denver metro:

Surface	Installed / sq ft	The trade
Pressure-treated pine	\$20 – \$35	Cheapest in; staining every 2–3 yrs
Cedar / redwood	\$25 – \$45	Real wood look; same upkeep clock
Capped composite	\$40 – \$70	No staining, 25–50 yr warranties
PVC / mineral board	\$50 – \$85	Top durability, coolest caps

Same substructure under all of them — the framing doesn't care what you walk on, which is why the cheap surface only saves the board delta, not half the deck.

The three multipliers bids get judged on

Height — walk-out / second story	+20–40%
Access — tight side yards, no machine access	+10–15%
Complexity — multi-level, angles, curves	+15–25%

These stack, and they're why two 320 sq ft decks can be \$14,000 and \$27,000 without either builder being wrong. An elevated deck is taller posts, engineered footings, railing at height, and staging — real structure, not margin. If a bid for a walk-out matches a bid for a ground-level deck, one of them misread the job.

A real bid, line by line

An itemized quote for a common project — replacing a worn-out 16×20 wood deck with capped composite, mid-height, 36 lin ft of aluminum railing, four steps:

Line item	Installed
Plans, permit & HOA paperwork	\$900
Demo & haul-off of the old deck	\$2,000
Footings & posts	\$2,600
Framing, ledger & hardware	\$4,900
Composite decking, installed	\$4,300
Aluminum railing, 36 lin ft	\$2,300
Stairs, 4 risers	\$1,100
Lighting rough-in & post caps	\$700
Total	\$18,800

Landing right in the middle of the 16×20 installed range once tear-out is counted. Yours will differ — the point is the shape: if a bid can't be broken into lines like these, you can't compare it to anything.

The add-ons bids include (and calculators don't)

Railing, installed (style decides)	\$30–90 / lin ft
Stairs, installed	\$150–400 / step
Concrete footings (4–8 per deck)	\$150–600 each
Permit fees, south Denver metro	\$200–500
Tear-out of an old deck	\$1,500–3,500

The big add-ons

Pergola over the deck	\$6,000–12,000
Solid-roof cover	\$15,000–28,000
Outdoor kitchen / built-in bar	\$8,000–25,000+
Lighting package	\$1,200–3,000

Covers and kitchens are engineered structures with their own permits — priced per project, not per square foot. They're also the classic phase-two items: build the deck framed to accept them now, add them next season.

The ten-year math

Wood wins the day-one bid and loses the decade. A 320 sq ft pressure-treated deck at roughly \$9,000 wants cleaning and re-staining every other year — \$400–900 each round if you hire it out — plus board and fastener repairs as UV and freeze-thaw do their work. Call it **\$3,000–5,000 over ten years**, on a surface that's aging anyway. The same deck in capped composite at \$16,000 needs soap, water, and nothing else, with 25–50 year fade-and-stain warranties. The gap narrows to a few thousand dollars over a decade — and past year ten, composite is simply ahead.

How to read a bid — the red flags

- 1 One lump-sum number.** If it isn't itemized roughly like the example above, you can't compare it — and change orders have nowhere honest to land.
- 2 No footing or hardware spec.** A real bid names footing depth and diameter, joist spacing, and the ledger fastening. "Per code" with no numbers is a shrug in writing.
- 3 Permits are "your problem."** A builder who won't pull the permit is a builder whose work has never been inspected. The permit protects you at resale.
- 4 Half down.** A deposit should cover materials mobilization, not the whole job's risk. Colorado norm is a modest deposit with payments tied to milestones.
- 5 No workmanship warranty in writing.** The boards carry 25–50 year manufacturer warranties; ask who stands behind the structure underneath, and for how long.

Honest ways to bring the number down

Keep the footprint a simple rectangle — corners and angles cost framing hours. Stay low if the yard allows it; height is the biggest multiplier on the list. Put the premium railing on the view side and standard aluminum everywhere else. Pick stock colors (special-order boards add cost and weeks). Phase the pergola or kitchen to next year on framing that's ready for them. And time it right — signing in the off-season buys schedule flexibility and a spring deck. What doesn't save money: skipping the permit, undersizing footings, or reusing framing nobody inspected — re-decking over sound framing is the legitimate version of that shortcut.

These are planning numbers from national cost surveys and manufacturer calculators — not a Haka bid. Elevated decks, walk-outs, and covered structures run above these ranges. Play with your own numbers at hakadecks.com/deck-cost-calculator — and when you're ready for a real number, that estimate is free. 720-589-5680.